



test, it got an overall score of 7,201. These are top-tier numbers that only a flagship phone in 2026 can achieve.

So, coming back to the gaming performance, it has been mostly amazing. For context, you can play BGMI at 120fps with stable performance. In Call of Duty Mobile, you can play at 120fps as well, with smooth gameplay and minor frame drops. However, in Gen-shin Impact, there are certain scenarios where you'll notice frame drops, but hey, you can still expect stable gameplay with an average 55fps performance.

CAMERAS

The Galaxy S26 comes with a triple camera setup, including a 50MP main sensor with OIS, a 12MP ultra-wide sensor, and a 10MP 3x telephoto lens. On the front, you get a 12MP selfie camera, which now offers a slightly wider field of view.

In daylight, the main camera performs very well. Images turn out detailed, sharp and vibrant. Speaking of colours, Samsung's image processing makes them pop, giving photos a more social media look. The main sensor also handles dynamic range quite well.

In tricky lighting, images tend to be slightly softer, with a bit of brightness, especially when trying to capture faces.

I also tried capturing moving subjects, but even a slight movement often resulted in missed shots or blur.

The 3x telephoto lens takes great pictures, offering good edge detection and an ample amount of background blur. The ultra-wide lens, too, captures good outdoor shots with decent detail and strong contrast.

Selfies turn out well, with good details, sharpness, and proper exposure. I particularly like the selfie camera's low-light performance, as the lens captures a good amount of detail in the output. For instance, in this photo, you can also see that it didn't add any blue tint to the sky, giving a more natural result, as I would prefer.

In terms of video recording, the main camera can shoot up to 8K at 30fps with stable footage. The ultra-wide and telephoto lenses can record videos up to 4K at 60fps, and the front camera also supports 4K video at 60fps.

BATTERY

This is the department where the Galaxy S26 feels behind the competition. Credit where credit is due, Samsung has increased the battery capacity to 4,300mAh from 4,000mAh on the Galaxy S25. There's only so much you can do with a compact phone if you want to keep it as light as the S26 is.

In real-world usage, the Galaxy S26 lasts about a full day with moderate use. I was mostly left with around 10% battery by the end of the day. So, the max you can expect out of this one is a

full day of us. Or you'll have to charge it mid-day if you're a heavy user.

Granted, if you want better battery life, you can go for the S26 Plus, or even the Ultra. But, I guess, that's the price of getting a compact one.

For those who care about numbers, in the PCMark battery drain test, it performed surprisingly well and gave 16 hours and 30 minutes of screen on time.

In terms of charging, the phone supports 25W wired charging and takes around 1 hour and 16 minutes to go from 0 to 100 per cent. The phone also supports 15W wireless charging.

VERDICT

The Galaxy S26 has not reinvented anything, but it is extremely refined. I am happy to report that the Galaxy S26 offers a solid user experience and is quite dependable. It gets almost everything right without trying too hard. Of course, the phone's greatest KSP has to be its compact form factor. Even other things, like the display and the performance is good enough for most users.

There are compromises for sure, like the battery life or charging may not be class leading. But if you want a compact flagship (there are only a handful of them) that delivers a premium experience without going into Ultra territory, the Galaxy S26 is a great option to consider. At Rs 87,999, it may not be perfect, but it is polished, capable and dependable in all the ways that actually matter.

—Siddharth Malhotra

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Exynos 2600 | Memory: 12 GB | Storage: 256/512 GB | Display: 6.3-inch FHD+ LTPO display | Brightness: 2650 nits | Refresh rate: 1-120 Hz Adaptive | Camera (Rear): 50MP + 12MP + 10MP | Camera (Front): 12 MP | Battery: 4,300 mAh | Charging: 25W wired and 15W wireless | IP Rating: IP68

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